

Family History Research Interview

For this family history interview, I interviewed my grandmother, who was born in Huehuetenango, Guatemala, but eventually moved to Quetzaltenango, where our family currently lives. I chose to interview her because her experiences helped me understand how our family came to live in Quetzaltenango and the challenges, traditions, and values that shaped the generations that followed.

Interview Questions

1. How did our family come to live in Quetzaltenango?
2. What challenges did our family face while raising the children?
3. How did the family overcome those challenges?
4. What traditions do you remember from when you were young?
5. What values did your parents teach you?
6. What experiences from our family are important for future generations to remember?
7. What advice would you like future generations of our family to remember?

According to my grandmother, "I always wanted to study, and I received a scholarship to study at the Instituto Nacional de Señoritas de Occidente (INSO)." This experience demonstrates how important education was to her from an early age. However, her father did not allow her to accept the scholarship because she would have needed to leave Huehuetenango and live in Quetzaltenango. Instead of giving up on her goals, she left her parents' home and moved to Quetzaltenango to work with an aunt. Later, she accompanied one of her cousins who came to study there. During that time, she had several jobs and eventually met my grandfather, who rented a place in the same house where she and her cousin lived. Their relationship developed gradually, and after some time, they eventually married.

One of the greatest challenges my grandmother's family faced was providing educational opportunities for her children despite financial difficulties. When my grandmother explained that her husband would only provide basic education and that her daughters would need to work if they wanted professional careers, I understood how important education was to her. She worked to help pay for her children's education and used part of the money available to support their studies. Her efforts, combined with the work and determination of her daughters and the scholarships they received, helped them continue their education. My mother, for example, graduated as a doctor with the help of a scholarship.

My grandmother also emphasized that faith, hope, effort, courage, loyalty, and responsibility helped the family overcome difficulties. She remembers traditions such as preparing honey and bread during Holy Week and visiting the cemetery on November 1 to remember deceased family members. She also explained that negative experiences, including prejudice and gossip, sometimes created divisions within the family and taught future generations the importance of avoiding those behaviors. Most importantly, she advised future generations, stating, "No matter where you come from, you can always

improve and change your story. It all depends on you." This interview helped me see how my family's history connects with my Personal History Project because my grandmother's experiences show me that our past can influence us, but it does not have to determine our future.

Reference

Samayoa Lopez, O. F. (2026, July 20). Personal interview.